Be Strong and of a Good Courage

We can face new and frightening seasons with courage, because God's presence goes with us and his word shows us the way.

Main passage	Joshua 1:1-9 (KJV)
Topic	Courage
Audience	adults
Length	about 45 minutes
Status	Draft: written by AI from the library, not yet reviewed by Dave

Suggested timing

Opening	4 min
Scripture	3 min
Background	5 min
Teaching point 1: God's presence continues when leaders pass	7 min
Teaching point 2: Courage is rooted in God's word	7 min
Teaching point 3: Fear not, for God goes with you	7 min
Discussion questions	7 min
Application	3 min
Closing prayer	2 min
Total	45 min

Opening (4 min)

Ask: "Think of a time you had to step into something new and frightening: a new job, a move, a diagnosis, a loss. What helped you take the first step?" Let several people share. Joshua stood at exactly that kind of moment.

Scripture (3 min)

Joshua 1:1-9

[1] Now after the death of Moses the servant of the LORD it came to pass, that the LORD spake unto Joshua the son of Nun, Moses' minister, saying, [2] Moses my servant is dead; now therefore arise, go over this Jordan, thou, and all this people, unto the land which I do give to them, even to the children of Israel. [3] Every place that the sole of your foot shall tread upon, that have I given unto you, as I said unto Moses. [4] From the wilderness and this Lebanon even unto the great river, the river Euphrates, all the land of the Hittites, and unto the great sea toward the going down of the sun, shall be your coast. [5] There shall not any

man be able to stand before thee all the days of thy life: as I was with Moses, so I will be with thee: I will not fail thee, nor forsake thee. [6] Be strong and of a good courage: for unto this people shalt thou divide for an inheritance the land, which I sware unto their fathers to give them. [7] Only be thou strong and very courageous, that thou mayest observe to do according to all the law, which Moses my servant commanded thee: turn not from it to the right hand or to the left, that thou mayest prosper whithersoever thou goest. [8] This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein: for then thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success. [9] Have not I commanded thee? Be strong and of a good courage; be not afraid, neither be thou dismayed: for the LORD thy God is with thee whithersoever thou goest.

Read the passage aloud. Ask the class to count how many times God says "be strong" or "be of good courage."

Background (5 min)

Moses was dead. For forty years he had led Israel out of Egypt and through the wilderness. Now Joshua, his assistant, had to lead a nation across the Jordan River into a land full of fortified cities. Joshua had been one of the two faithful spies forty years earlier (Numbers 14:6-9), so he knew both the promise and the danger.

God speaks to Joshua three times about courage in these nine verses. Notice what God does not do: he does not say the task will be easy. He gives Joshua his presence, his promise and his word.

Teacher note: The conquest of Canaan raises hard questions for many readers. This lesson focuses on what God says to Joshua personally about trusting him in a frightening new task.

Teaching point 1: God's presence continues when leaders pass (7 min)

"Moses my servant is dead; now therefore arise" (v. 2). The great leader was gone, but God was not. "As I was with Moses, so I will be with thee: I will not fail thee, nor forsake thee" (v. 5). Every generation faces losses. The same God who was with those before us is with us now.

Supporting verses

Joshua 1:1-5 (read from the Bible)

Deuteronomy 31:8: And the LORD, he it is that doth go before thee; he will be with thee, he will not fail thee, neither forsake thee: fear not, neither be dismayed.

Hebrews 13:5-6: Let your conversation be without covetousness; and be content with such things as ye have: for he hath said, I will never leave thee, nor forsake thee. So that we may boldly say, The Lord is my helper, and I will not fear what man shall do unto me.

> *"it is a great comfort to the rising generation of ministers and Christians that the same grace which was sufficient for those that went before them shall not be wanting to them"*
>
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Joshua 1:1-9

> *"Because God shall be with thee, therefore thou shalt be irresistible."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Joshua 1:5

Handout blanks (answers)

As I was with Moses, so I will be with **thee**.

I will not fail thee, nor **forsake** thee.

Teaching point 2: Courage is rooted in God's word (7 min)

Joshua's courage was not to come from his own personality but from obeying God's word: "This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night" (v. 8). Courage and obedience go together. When we know what God has said, we can step out even when we are afraid.

Supporting verses

Joshua 1:6-8: Be strong and of a good courage: for unto this people shalt thou divide for an inheritance the land, which I sware unto their fathers to give them. Only be thou strong and very courageous, that thou mayest observe to do according to all the law, which Moses my servant commanded thee: turn not from it to the right hand or to the left, that thou mayest prosper whithersoever thou goest. This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein: for then thou shalt make thy way prosperous, and then thou shalt have good success.

Psalm 1:1-3: Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly, nor standeth in the way of sinners, nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful. But his delight is in the law of the LORD; and in his law doth he meditate day and night. And he shall be like a tree planted by the rivers of water, that bringeth forth his fruit in his season; his leaf also shall not wither; and whatsoever he doeth shall prosper.

Psalm 119:105: Thy word is a lamp unto my feet, and a light unto my path.

> *"The law which had already been written by Moses, and from which he and the people were to take all those precepts by which their lives were to be governed."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Joshua 1:8

> *"Be strong therefore, and play the man to the uttermost."*
> — Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Joshua 1:7

Handout blanks (answers)

This book of the law shall not **depart** out of thy mouth.

Courage and **obedience** go together.

Teaching point 3: Fear not, for God goes with you (7 min)

Verse 9 is the summary: "Have not I commanded thee? Be strong and of a good courage; be not afraid, neither be thou dismayed: for the LORD thy God is with thee whithersoever thou goest." Courage is not the absence of fear; it is moving forward in obedience because God is present.

Supporting verses

Joshua 1:9: Have not I commanded thee? Be strong and of a good courage; be not afraid, neither be thou dismayed: for the LORD thy God is with thee whithersoever thou goest.

Isaiah 41:10: Fear thou not; for I am with thee: be not dismayed; for I am thy God: I will strengthen thee; yea, I will help thee; yea, I will uphold thee with the right hand of my righteousness.

Matthew 28:20: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

> *"Those that go where God sends them shall have him with them wherever they go"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Joshua 1:1-9

> *"When we are in the way of our duty we have reason to be strong and very courageous"*
> — Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Joshua 1:1-9

Handout blanks (answers)

Be not afraid, neither be thou **dismayed**.

The LORD thy God is with thee **whithersoever** thou goest.

Discussion questions (7 min)

1. Why do you think God repeated "be strong and of a good courage" three times?

Joshua needed it; fear returns, and God patiently reassures us again and again.

2. What "Jordan River" are you facing, a new or frightening step?

Answers will vary.

3. How does knowing God's word give courage?

It tells us God's character and promises and shows us the right path, so we are not guided by fear.

4. Is courage the absence of fear? If not, what is it?

No; it is acting rightly in spite of fear, trusting God's presence.

Application (3 min)

Write Joshua 1:9 on a card and read it every morning this week. Name one step of obedience you have been afraid to take, and take it, trusting that God goes with you. Encourage someone else who is facing a hard new season.

Closing prayer (2 min)

Lord, you were with Moses and with Joshua, and you are with us. When we face new and frightening places, make us strong and of good courage. Keep your word in our mouths and hearts. Thank you for your promise never to fail or forsake us. Go with us wherever we go. In Jesus' name, Amen.

Sources quoted

Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible, on Joshua 1:1-9

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Joshua 1:5

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Joshua 1:8

Adam Clarke, Commentary on the Bible, on Joshua 1:7

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